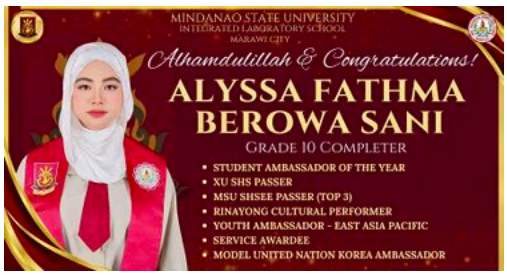
Alyssa Fathma Berowa Sani

Alyssa Fathma Berowa Sani is a Maranao student leader, youth diplomat, and cultural advocate from Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, in the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM), Philippines. A graduating Senior High School student at the Mindanao State University – Integrated Laboratory School (MSU-ILS) in 2026, she has built a remarkable record of academic achievement, international exchange, cultural performance, and community service while still in secondary school. Her accomplishments — from placing in the top three of a competitive university-level entrance examination to serving as a U.S. Department of State-recognized youth ambassador — have drawn attention to the capacity and potential of young Bangsamoro women in national and global arenas.

Alyssa Fathma Berowa Sani



Born	Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Maranao (Bangsamoro)
Religion	Islam
School	MSU-Integrated Laboratory School, Marawi City
Expected Graduation	2026 (Senior High School)
Known for	MSU SHSEE Top 3; YA-EAP Ambassador; MUN Korea Ambassador; Cultural Performer; Student Ambassador of the Year
Exchange Program	The Storm King School, Cornwall-on-Hudson, New York, USA

Contents

1 Background and Family
2 Education
  2.1 MSU-Integrated Laboratory School
  2.2 MSU Senior High School Entrance Examination (SHSEE) — Top 3
  2.3 International Exchange — The Storm King School, New York
  2.4 Xavier University – Senior High School (XU SHS) Passer
3 Youth Leadership and Ambassadorial Roles
  3.1 YA-EAP Ambassador
  3.2 Model United Nations Korea Ambassador
  3.3 Student Ambassador of the Year
4 Cultural Advocacy
  4.1 Rinayong Cultural Performer
5 Recognition and Awards
6 Cultural and Historical Significance
7 See Also
8 References

Background and Family

Alyssa Fathma Berowa Sani was born and raised in Marawi City, the capital of Lanao del Sur and the seat of Maranao intellectual and cultural life in the Bangsamoro. The city, perched above the shores of Lake Lanao and long considered the heart of Maranao civilization, has produced generations of scholars, artists, and community

leaders. Growing up in this environment shaped Alyssa's early orientation toward both academic achievement and cultural preservation — two values that define her public profile as a young person.

Her full name reflects that layered identity: **Fathma** is a variant of Fatimah, the daughter of the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him), signaling a faith-rooted naming tradition common among Maranao Muslim families; **Berowa** is a prominent surname within the MSU academic community, linking her to a lineage associated with learning and public service; and **Sani** grounds her firmly in Maranao heritage. Together, the name tells a story about where she comes from and what her community expects of her.

Education

MSU-Integrated Laboratory School

Alyssa is an upcoming 2026 graduate of the **Mindanao State University – Integrated Laboratory School (MSU-ILS)**, one of the most respected pre-collegiate institutions in Muslim Mindanao. Established in 1964 on the MSU Main Campus in Marawi City, MSU-ILS serves as a laboratory school for the university's College of Education, enrolling students from kindergarten through Senior High School. It operates within the academic culture of MSU-Marawi — a institution established in 1961 as a social laboratory for national integration and the first state university in Mindanao. For Alyssa, studying within this ecosystem meant being immersed in an environment that prizes both rigorous scholarship and multicultural engagement from an early age.

MSU Senior High School Entrance Examination (SHSEE) — Top 3

One of Alyssa's most concrete academic distinctions is her **Top 3 placement** in the **Senior High School Entrance Examination (SHSEE)** administered by Mindanao State University. The SHSEE is a competitive and highly selective examination that screens applicants for the Senior High School program within the MSU System — a process that draws hundreds of applicants across the region each cycle. Placing in the top three puts Alyssa among the highest-performing examinees, a distinction that reflects not just test-taking ability but the sustained academic discipline that comes from years of preparation.

International Exchange — The Storm King School, New York

Perhaps the most internationally significant chapter of Alyssa's secondary education was her stint as an exchange student at **The Storm King School (SKS)** in Cornwall-on-Hudson, New York, United States. Founded in 1867, The Storm King School is a distinguished coeducational boarding and day school serving students in Grades 8 through 12 and postgraduate, with an enrollment drawn from the United States and more than twenty countries worldwide. The school is known for its low student-to-faculty ratio and its global exchange program, which brings international students into a rigorous academic environment alongside their American peers.

For a young Maranao woman from Marawi City — a city that only a few years prior had been the site of a devastating five-month urban siege in 2017 — the opportunity to study in an elite New York boarding school carries extraordinary weight. Her time at Storm King gave her firsthand exposure to American academic culture, cross-cultural dialogue, and the kind of global learning environment that few students from the Bangsamoro region have had the chance to access.

Xavier University – Senior High School (XU SHS) Passer

Alyssa also passed the entrance examination for Senior High School at **Xavier University – Ateneo de Cagayan** in Cagayan de Oro City. XU is a Filipino, Catholic, and Jesuit university known for its rigorous academic standards and selective admissions process, and successfully passing its senior high school qualifying exam speaks to the breadth of Alyssa's academic preparation — strong enough to open doors at competitive institutions across different educational traditions.

Youth Leadership and Ambassadorial Roles

YA-EAP Ambassador

Alyssa served as an ambassador under the **Youth Ambassadors – East Asia and Pacific (YA-EAP) Program**, a fully funded youth leadership exchange sponsored by the **U.S. Department of State's Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs (ECA)**. The YA-EAP program brings together young leaders aged 15 to 17 from across the East Asia and Pacific region — including the Philippines, Burma, Papua New Guinea, Fiji, and other Pacific nations — for leadership development, civic engagement, and community problem-solving workshops, typically held in the United States. Participants stay with host families and engage in sessions on democracy, digital engagement, conflict resolution, and inclusive leadership. The program is administered by PH International and recognized as one of the U.S. government's premier people-to-people exchange initiatives.

Being named a YA-EAP Ambassador places Alyssa in a cohort selected from hundreds of applicants based on criteria including academic achievement, leadership potential, community engagement, English proficiency, and commitment to social inclusion. For a student from Marawi City — in a region often associated in the international imagination with conflict rather than diplomacy — her selection signals a broader story about the Bangsamoro's emerging generation of globally connected young people.

Model United Nations Korea Ambassador

Alyssa also participated as an ambassador in the **Model United Nations (MUN) Korea** circuit — a platform that brings together youth delegates from across Asia to simulate UN deliberations and develop skills in diplomacy, research, and international relations. MUN Korea events, including high-profile gatherings like the Asia World Model United Nations (AWMUN) held in Seoul, regularly draw hundreds of young delegates from countries including South Korea, the Philippines, Indonesia, the United States, and Mongolia. Participating as an ambassador in such a forum requires mastery of position papers, formal debate procedures, and international issue analysis — skills that go well beyond the typical secondary school curriculum.

Student Ambassador of the Year

Within her own school community, Alyssa was recognized as **Student Ambassador of the Year** — an acknowledgment of her consistent role as a representative of her institution across multiple platforms, from community service to international exchange. This kind of school-level recognition, layered on top of her external accomplishments, paints the picture of a student who doesn't just compete in external arenas but brings that energy back into her home institution.

Cultural Advocacy

Rinayong Cultural Performer

Alyssa is a recognized **Rinayong Cultural Performer**, situating her within the tradition of Maranao cultural expression and indigenous performing arts. Maranao performance culture is rich and historically significant — encompassing dances like the *Singkil*, the *Pagapir*, and the *Kappa Malong*, accompanied by the kulintang and agung, instruments central to the musical heritage of the "people of the lake." The Rinayong is a form of cultural performance that celebrates Maranao identity through song, movement, and attire, and has long been a vehicle for transmitting community values and artistic memory across generations.

In a generation that is often pulled between modernization and cultural continuity, Alyssa's active participation in cultural performance is both a personal choice and a community statement. It reflects the Bangsamoro's ongoing project of reclaiming and asserting their cultural identity — particularly in the aftermath of the 2017 Marawi siege, which not only displaced thousands but also threatened the physical and symbolic spaces where Maranao culture had been practiced and preserved for centuries.

Recognition and Awards

The following honors have been conferred on or associated with Alyssa Fathma Berowa Sani in the course of her secondary education:

Award / Recognition	Details
Student Ambassador of the Year	School-level recognition for outstanding ambassadorial service across academic and community platforms
MSU SHSEE Passer – Top 3	Top 3 placement in the Mindanao State University Senior High School Entrance Examination
XU SHS Passer	Passed the Senior High School entrance examination of Xavier University – Ateneo de Cagayan
YA-EAP Ambassador	Youth Ambassadors – East Asia and Pacific Program, U.S. Department of State Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs
Model United Nations Korea Ambassador	Delegate and ambassador in a Korea-based MUN forum
Rinayong Cultural Performer	Recognized performer in Maranao indigenous cultural arts
Service Awardee	Recognized for contributions to community and institutional service

Cultural and Historical Significance

Alyssa Fathma Berowa Sani's story is inseparable from the story of Marawi City itself. The city that shaped her early years was also the city that bore one of the most destructive conflicts in recent Philippine history — the 2017 Battle of Marawi, a five-month urban siege that displaced hundreds of thousands of residents, damaged or destroyed much of the city's historic center, and left deep psychological and material wounds on the Maranao community. Many of the young people who grew up in Marawi in the years after 2017 did so amid reconstruction, displacement, and the slow, painful work of rebuilding not just buildings but community identity.

Against that backdrop, the emergence of a young Maranao woman who has earned a top ranking in a university entrance exam, studied in a New York boarding school, represented her country in youth diplomatic programs, and performed her culture on public stages carries a significance that goes well beyond individual achievement. She is, in a very real sense, a visible answer to the narrative of decline — proof that Marawi's next generation is not defined by the siege, but by resilience, scholarship, and cultural pride.

See Also

- Mindanao State University
- MSU-Integrated Laboratory School
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Maranao people
- Singkil (dance)
- Youth Ambassadors Program

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